Challenge Stigma / Find Peace

FrontlineFolks | Guide #28

Emotional Numbness and Wanting to Feel Again

A Field Guide for Frontline Folks and Their Families

Field notes for the pattern in this chapter.

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Disclaimer

This guide is for general education only.

It is not:

- Therapy
- Medical care
- A crisis service
- Individualized advice

Reading this guide does not create a therapist–client relationship with the author or with Never Forgotten Services, PLLC.

If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself or someone else, call 988 in the United States, go to your nearest emergency room, or contact your local emergency services.

If you want mental health treatment, please contact a licensed provider in your state or call the number on the back of your insurance card.

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1. What Is Happening

Emotional numbness is your nervous system's way of protecting you when the world feels too dangerous to feel anything. After months or years of threat, you find yourself not feeling much of anything—not joy, not sadness, not desire, not anger. Things that mattered to you (time with family, hobbies, sex, connection) now feel flat and uninteresting. This isn't depression exactly (though it can be), and it's not that you don't care. It's that your nervous system has learned that feeling things makes you vulnerable, so it shuts down feeling as a survival strategy.

Common signs of emotional numbness

- Flatness: Things that used to excite you feel boring or irrelevant.
- Emotional distance: You can hear your partner say 'I love you' but don't feel it.
- Reduced desire: Sex, intimacy, and connection all feel like obligations, not longings.
- Difficulty accessing emotions: You can't cry, can't get angry, can't feel scared—even when those feelings would fit.
- Loss of interest: Hobbies, friends, activities you loved now seem pointless.
- Watching yourself from outside: Feeling like you're observing your life instead of living it (depersonalization/derealization).
- Going through motions: You can do things, but they feel hollow and empty.

> **Numbness is not failure:**
> It's an indicator that your nervous system has been under siege. Numbness is a protective adaptation, not a character flaw or sign you don't love your partner.

2. Why It Escalates

Frontline work teaches you not to feel. On the job, fear kills decision-making, grief slows you down, and all emotion is a liability. You train yourself to dissociate—to observe without reacting, to feel nothing. That neural pathway gets reinforced hundreds of times. Then you come home expecting to flip it off, but you can't. You're still in protective numbness. Your partner tries to connect and you can't feel it. You try to access desire and it's like trying to light a match underwater.

How numbness deepens

- Repeated suppression of emotion: You learn not to feel at work, then can't turn it back on at home.

- High cortisol from chronic stress: Cortisol suppresses serotonin and dopamine, both required for motivation and connection.
- Avoidance of triggering moments: You stop pursuing intimacy or connection because it feels risky.
- Partner frustration: Your partner feels rejected, and you withdraw more because you feel like a failure.
- Layers of guilt: Being numb + guilt about being numb + resentment about being broken creates more shutdown.
- Reinforced protective response: Every time you don't feel, you prove (to your nervous system) that numbness keeps you safe.

> *Why this works: reducing total load and increasing predictability lowers baseline arousal and improves regulation.*

3. What To Do This Week

You can't force feeling to come back, but you can create conditions where it becomes safe to feel again. This requires nervous system regulation first, then gradual re-engagement with feeling.

1. Reduce activation with nervous system tools: Breathing, movement, cold exposure, time in nature. Lower baseline arousal = more capacity for feeling.
2. Practice micro-connections without expectation: Hold partner's hand for 5 minutes without needing to feel anything. Just notice. Repeat daily.
3. Name emotions when you notice them, even small ones: 'I felt a little sadness then' or 'That made me slightly angry.' Labeling rewires the brain.
4. Differentiate between body feeling and emotion feeling: Maybe you can't feel emotions, but you CAN feel physical sensations. Start there (touch, temperature, texture).
5. Use music, nature, or movement to access feeling: These bypass the analytical brain and directly activate emotion centers.
6. Seek therapy that focuses on somatic/body-based work: EMDR, somatic experiencing, or trauma-focused therapy all help restore capacity to feel.
7. Stop forcing intimacy: Take sex off the table temporarily. Start with non-sexual touch and see if that feels safer.

> Field rule: set the bar low enough to do it even on your worst day.

4. For Partners and Team

Stress communication should be clear, brief, and repeatable. Predictable routines protect relationships.

- Use concrete language about numbness: 'I want to feel connection but my nervous system is shut down. This isn't about you.'
- Agree on a patience timeline: Recovery from numbness doesn't happen fast. Ask for patience without expecting immediate change.
- Debrief without pressure: 'I felt a tiny bit of sadness today' or 'I noticed I laughed and actually meant it.' Celebrate micro-progress.
- Consent, pacing, and emotional safety are part of intimacy, not separate from it: No sex pressure. No 'you should be able to feel by now.' Just space to heal.

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5. When To Get More Help

Self-guided tools are a start. Escalate care when symptoms persist, spread, or begin harming safety and function.

- Numbness is spreading: You're now numb at work too, losing capacity to do your job effectively.
- Partner intimacy is completely absent: Relationship is at risk if connection doesn't start rebuilding.
- Anhedonia is severe: You can't access positive emotion about anything, and it's worsening.
- Suicidal ideation shows up with the numbness: Numb + hopeless is a dangerous combination.
- Sex therapy or trauma-informed couples care can accelerate recovery (EMDR, somatic therapy, specialized trauma treatment).

6. 7-Day Field Drill

Use the worksheet every day for one week. Track trigger, body signal, and reset action. Keep what works and remove what does not.

> **Daily drill:**
> 1) Name the trigger.
> 2) Name the first body signal.
> 3) Run one reset action.
> 4) Log response quality.

Worksheet 1: Worksheet: Emotional Numbness and Wanting to Feel Again

Use this to track the pattern in this chapter and build a practical response you can repeat under load.

Where did this pattern show up this week?

List specific moments at work, at home, and in transition.

What did it cost you when it took over?

Name impact on body, mood, decisions, and relationships.

What two actions will you run for the next 7 days?

Choose actions small enough to use on hard days.

1. Trigger:
What activated the pattern?

2. Early body signal:
What did your body do first?

3. Reset action used:
What fast action lowered intensity?

4. Better next response:
What exact behavior will you use next time?

> Track this daily for one week, then tighten the plan around what actually worked.

Worksheet 2: Worksheet: Emotional Numbness and Wanting to Feel Again - Partner/Team Check-In

Use this page for one short practical check-in each week.

What do others notice first when this pattern is active?

Capture observable behavior, not labels.

What support helps most and least?

List what helps and what escalates the issue.

What agreement will you both practice this week?

One clear action from each side.

1. Signal phrase:

What phrase means pause and reset?

2. Time-to-return commitment:

When will re-engagement happen?

3. Repair step:

What specific repair happens after a rupture?

> Keep check-ins short, specific, and repeatable.

Closing

You've seen and carried more than most people will ever know.

Blow ups and shutdowns are not proof that you're broken or that your relationship is doomed.

They are signs that your nervous system has been running in survival mode for a long time.

The fact that you picked up this guide and read it matters.

You are choosing to be intentional about how you show up for the people who matter to you.

That choice is a lot more powerful than having flawless days.

About the Author

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Michael is a U.S. Army combat veteran and licensed clinical social worker who specializes in working with military, veterans, and first responders—our frontline folks. After leaving the military, he spent years fighting his own demons and trying to figure out why he could hold it together on the job but feel completely wrecked at home. The turning point was realizing he wasn't the only one living that split life—and that nobody should have to feel that alone, confused, or broken by what the job asks of them.

Since then, his work has focused on trauma, the impact of high-stress jobs on home life, and helping families make sense of what the job brings home. He uses plain language, zero shame, and a "you're not crazy, this actually makes sense" approach to help frontline folks and their families understand what's happening in their nervous systems and learn how to move through the chaos together.